

THE LONG WAIT

For much of the past decade, India's pursuit of an ICC ODI title had ended in familiar disappointment. From the 2017 Champions Trophy final to the heartbreak of the 2023 World Cup at home, the Men in Blue repeatedly fell at the final hurdle.

That script finally changed in 2025.

On March 9, at the Dubai International Stadium, Ravindra Jadeja's pull off Will O'Rourke sealed a four-wicket win over New Zealand and handed India its first ICC ODI trophy in 12 years, in the Champions Trophy final.

India's title run was built on collective authority. Varun Chakaravathy and Mohammed Shami finished with nine wickets each, leading the bowling charts, while Kuldeep Yadav delivered at key moments, including two wickets in the final and three against Pakistan, as India went unbeaten through the tournament.

The batting, too, carried depth and timing. Rohit Sharma, Shubman Gill, Virat Kohli, Shreyas Iyer and K.L. Rahul all contributed when it mattered. Kohli reclaimed his 'chase master' tag with an unbeaten century against Pakistan and a composed 84 in the semifinal against Australia.

In the final, Rohit's 76 set the tone, before Rahul, pushed down the order, anchored the chase with an unbeaten 34 alongside Jadeja to complete a long-awaited triumph.



THE LONG NIGHT

"It's never over until it's over" found its purest expression at the French Open in 2025, when Carlos Alcaraz produced a comeback for the ages in one of the greatest Grand Slam finals ever at Court Philippe-Chatrier.

Facing world No. 1 Jannik Sinner, Alcaraz appeared on the brink as the Italian surged towards his maiden Roland Garros title. Sinner led by two sets and was up 5-3 in the fourth, holding three match points with Alcaraz staring at 0-40.

What followed was a stunning reversal. Alcaraz saved all three match points, clawed his way back, and eventually prevailed 4-6, 6-7 (4), 6-4, 7-6 (3), 7-6 (10-2) in a contest that stretched deep into the Paris night.

The drama refused to fade. After more than three hours and 40 minutes, Sinner had his first match point. Over five hours in, Alcaraz served for the championship at 5-4, only for Sinner to drag the match back to 6-6. The decider came down to a final-set tiebreaker, where the momentum swung decisively.

Roared on by a partisan crowd, Alcaraz raced to a 4-0 lead and never looked back, sealing victory with a sublime forehand pass before collapsing in disbelief.

The longest men's final in French Open history, and the second-longest Grand Slam final ever, delivered Alcaraz his fifth Major title.

